

RAHUL IRANI



Delhi **SHOW CAUSE**

"Mobs go on a rampage without reasoning why they are doing so."

SURENDER S. YADAV, ADDL. DCP, DELHI

On August 30, a mob thrashed school teacher Uma Khurana and went on a rampage in the streets after a TV channel showed her forcing girls into prostitution. It later turned out that the video tape was doctored and the sting operation was carried out at the behest of a businessman who sought to settle scores with Khurana.

BIHAR	UTTAR PRADESH	DELHI	MUMBAI
1 policeman per 1,745 citizens	1 policeman per 1,500 citizens	1 policeman for 290 citizens	1 policeman for 260 citizens
AVERAGE TIME FOR THE COMPLETION OF THE LEGAL PROCESS IN LOWER COURTS*			
Five years	Between 7-8 years	Between 7-10 years	Two years

(*Figures for criminal cases sourced from lawyers in four regions keeping in mind court delays and time spent in interrogation)

tening to them, when they get no active response from the state, it is out of frustration". One of the women who tried to set fire to a Chennai commuter train said, "We did it in a momentary fit of anger... but it had been building over the month as our trains were delayed without any notice." The other kind of mob violence, says Bajpai, is as common today as a real sense of agitation. It is the lawlessness to get attention. "You see members of a mob laughing, running around and having fun because they know that cameras are covering them." This is the mob for hire, without a cause, a byproduct of urban unemployment and poverty. "Youth standing on the streets doing nothing because they don't have jobs... they are always willing to join in," Bajpai says.

The Delhi Police now have a clearer picture of what set off the violence in Daryaganj around the fake sting operation (see box above). They have arrested 30 people, none of them

the so-called 'protesting parents' as reported in the media. Local people got agitated because the television channel running the sting was airing live telecasts from outside Khurana's school. In the Thane domestic servant molestation case, the small self-styled 'sangathanas' (groups) of domestic maids, who broke into Prakash Shetty's home, have disappeared.

The response of the state has been to concentrate on acoustics: the Nitish Kumar Government threatened to slap collective fines on people indulging in mob justice. It did not follow through on its words though and the police even threw the bodies of the lynched victims into the Ganges. There are indications that the Bihar Government refused to take action to prevent its rivals from deriving political mileage out of it. The Dhampurwa accused are known to be influential residents of the underdevel-

oped agrarian locality dominated by caste affiliations.

Nikhil Kumar, MP from Bihar and former special secretary, internal security, finds state passivity and tacit approval in such incidents "disturbing"—like in Bhagalpur this year, when the thief, beaten by the locals, was dragged from a police motorcycle until he passed out. The act, he says, is like an expression of the ordinary beat constable's "lack of confidence in the police hierarchy, a feeling that they would be able to get away with it".

The efficacy of violence as a tool of collective protest was put to lethal use in the Gujar agitation when after years of trying through conventional means, to get anyone to pay attention towards their drive for Scheduled Tribe status, the Gujjars upped the ante. They disrupted traffic in the tourist-intensive 'golden triangle' region of Agra-Delhi-Jaipur, uprooted railway lines and attacked property, cost 26 lives but put their issue on national agenda.

The aftershock of such incidents is felt much later. The violence around the Agra Shab-e-Barat procession quickly turned communal and curfew had to be imposed in several parts of

"We have not got rations for 11 months. We are starving and the administration is not listening to us—what should we do?"

HIMINGSHU DAS, 'RATION RIOT' PROTESTER IN BIRBHUM, WEST BENGAL

